

DELHI | Maritime Mystery



ADMIRAL VERMA

JYOTI KAPOOR

A year after 26/11, inter-governmental rivalry continues to stall the appointment of a maritime security adviser (MSA). The MSA, a vice-admiral from the navy, is to coordinate with 15 agencies responsible for coastal security to prevent terrorists from slipping through. Defence Minister A.K. Antony has said the MSA would be appointed soon but gave no deadline. Navy Chief Admiral Nirmal Verma recently said that the navy had made its case and it was now up to the Government to make up its mind. "Whatever we had to say has been projected," he said, adding that the delay was because of "one agency that feels they have a much larger role to play and hence they should head it". The allusion appears to be to the Home Ministry which wants the MSA to report to the home minister. The navy wants the MSA to report to the national security adviser. The recommendation is frozen.

by Sandeep Unnithan

KOLKATA | Star Wars

At a seminar on astronomy last week, West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya raised many an eyebrow saying astronomy was "all bunkum" and that it was no science. The audience, full of the astronomy faithful and top astronomers on the dais, was stupefied. The chief minister thundered on, picking holes in astronomy, calling it a load of rubbish. When someone pointed it out to him, Bhattacharya corrected himself: "What I wanted to say is astrology is bunkum, not astronomy." The story, however, does not end here. A group of Kolkata astrologers have united and decided to take the chief minister to court for denigrating their profession. One of the old-timers Bhrigu said "How can the chief minister say something so derogatory about someone's job?" For Bhattacharya, it is now all in the stars.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

BUDDHADEB BHATTACHARYA SHOCKS ALL AT AN ASTRONOMY SEMINAR CALLING IT BUNKUM. HE MEANT ASTROLOGY OF COURSE.

MUMBAI | Fruit Row

Maharashtra Chief Minister Ashok Chavan is in the centre of yet another storm. A Swiss company, Citrus International, which was to set up an orange processing plant in Vidarbha, has decided to relocate the plant to Nanded, Chavan's hometown. This is likely to provoke anger in Vidarbha, which has already demanded statehood. The reason for the location change is still a mystery but the state's largest orange-producing region stands to lose an investment opportunity of Rs 170 crore.

By Malini Bhupta

MUMBAI'S NEW ELECTRICAL SUBURBAN TRAINS CURB CARBON EMISSIONS BY 40 PER CENT

MUMBAI | Green Wheels

India may have recently vowed to slash carbon emissions by 20-25 per cent but Mumbai's new electrical suburban trains are already speeding ahead of this target. These local trains curb carbon emissions by 40 per cent and save 30 per cent more electricity than a normal train. The saving is made through the regenerative braking system, which reuses electricity for other trains on the same line. Since 2007, no less than 75 "green" trains have been rolled out and 200 will be in motion by 2014. The scheme will boost Mumbai's green credentials as it battles to shed its tag as one of India's most polluted cities. The new trains are being bought under the Rs 4,500-crore World Bank-funded Mumbai Urban Transport Project.

by Nishika Patel

